

(GAME NAME) — Baseline Rules

Version: 2026-05-30. Source of truth for all test scenario rule sheets.

Do not edit this file during a playtest — use the layer-specific rule sheet instead.

Introduction

(GAME NAME) is a 2-player abstract-tactical board game. There is no luck — no dice, no hidden information. Every decision is made with full knowledge of the board.

What you command: Each player leads an army of Guards and Champions, all serving a King. Guards are fast, Champions carry powerful skills. Your King is the most important piece on the board — and the target.

How you win: Capture the opponent's King. The game ends immediately when a King is removed.

How a game flows: Players alternate turns. On your turn you first move your pieces (and attack), then activate skills. Piece capture, skill combos, and board control build toward the moment you threaten — and take — the enemy King.

What makes it deep: Skills cost Money. Money is scarce. You will always want to do more than you can. That tension — between movement, attacks, and skill combos — is the game.

Simple Overview

A surface-level map of every system. No edge cases — just what each thing does.

Rounds and turns: The game is played in Rounds. Each Round, P1 takes a full turn, then P2. A turn has two phases: Move Phase, then Skill Phase.

Move Phase: You have 2 actions. Spend one to move a piece up to its speed. Each piece can only be moved once per phase.

Move-Attack: Instead of moving into empty space, spend an action to move your piece onto an enemy tile. The enemy takes 1 damage.

Health: Every piece has 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. Taking 1 damage moves a piece one step along that track. Injured pieces are slower and have shorter skill range.

Armor: A piece can hold up to 3 Armor. Each point absorbs 1 incoming damage **before** HP is affected, then is destroyed.

Skill Phase: You have actions (starting at 2 per turn). Spend one action + Money to activate an equipped skill on one of your Champions or King.

Money: Your currency. You earn it automatically each turn (starting at +2/turn, scaling up over time). Skills cost Money.

Skills and Path: Skills travel in a straight line from the caster (like a chess Queen). That path is blocked by any piece in the way. Most skills have a default range of 2 tiles.

Bodyguard: When a Champion or King is hit by a Move-Attack, you can choose to have an adjacent Guard take the hit instead.

Skill Drafting: Before the game, players alternate picking skills from a shared pool and assigning them to their Champions and King. Each piece gets 2 skills.

Progression: As the game goes on, your Money income and the number of actions in your Skill Phase both grow — late-game turns are more powerful because you can cast more skills.

For full rules and edge cases, read the sections below.

Goal

Capture the opponent's **King**. The game ends immediately when a King is removed from the board.

Draw conditions:

- No piece has been captured for 10 consecutive full rounds.
- Only the two Kings remain on the board.

Components

Per player: 1 King · 5 Champions · 6 Guards

Shared (Prototype): 10x10 grid board · Skill cards · Injured markers · Armor pieces

Skill Drafting

- Lay out all available skills face-up as a shared pool.
- Alternating draft: P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King → P2 picks 2 skills and assigns freely → repeat.
- Continue until all 5 Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills.
- Both players draft from the same pool. Duplicates are allowed.

Setup

- **Board:** Use the 10x10 grid.
- **First player:** Flip a coin (or decide verbally).
- **Piece placement:** Each player places pieces on their own back two rows:
 - Back row (row 1/10): King in the centre, Champions fill the remaining 5 spaces.
 - Second row (row 2/9): All 6 Guards.
- **Skill Draft:** Alternating picks. P1 picks 2 skills from the pool and assigns them freely to any of their Champions or King, then P2. Repeat until all Champions and the King on each side have 2 skills each (12 per player). Duplicates allowed.
- **Starting Money:** Each player starts with **6 Money**.
- P1 begins Round 1.

Round Structure

A **Round** = P1's Turn + P2's Turn.

At the **start of each player's turn** (before they do anything), that player collects their Money income. (*Exception: Round 1 — players begin with their starting Money and collect nothing before their first turn.*)

Turn Structure

Each **Turn** has two phases, in order:

- **Move Phase** — spend actions to move pieces (and attack).
- **Skill Phase** — spend actions to activate skills.

You may use 0 actions in either phase.

Move Phase

You have **2 actions** per turn. Spend 1 action to move one piece — either **into empty space** (normal movement) or **into an enemy tile** (a Move-Attack — see next section). **Each piece may only be moved once per Move Phase.**

Piece	Normal speed	Injured speed
Guard	2 tiles	1 tile
Champion / King	1 tile	1 tile

Free pathing: A piece may move in any direction — horizontal, vertical, diagonal — taking any route up to its speed in tiles. The route does not have to be a straight line.

Pieces block movement: A moving piece cannot pass through any other piece, ally or opponent.

- *Exception:* A piece may go around a blocking piece if total tiles moved stays within speed (e.g. a Guard using 2 diagonal moves to go around a piece directly in the way).

Move-Attack

A **Move-Attack** is a Move that ends on an enemy tile. Spend 1 action to move your piece **onto a tile occupied by an enemy piece.**

- Deal **1 damage** to the enemy.
- **If the enemy is removed:** your piece occupies the tile (the attack consumed the move; remaining unused movement tiles do not carry over).
- **If the enemy survives** (Armor absorbed the damage): your piece **stops on the tile immediately before the target.** This applies to **every** attacker — a Guard with speed 2 ends up having moved only 1 tile; a Champion or King with speed 1 does not move at all. Either way the damage is dealt. *(If multiple paths reach the target, you choose which one — important for the Bodyguard Rule.)*

You may attack with one action and move a different piece with the other action in the same turn.

Move-Attacks are how pieces deal damage with movement alone. Skills — activated in the Skill Phase — are the other way pieces affect each other, and use different rules (Path, Range, Money).

Bodyguard Rule

When you make a **Move-Attack** against an opponent's Champion or King, the defender may choose to have a Guard intercept — **if a friendly Guard is on a tile adjacent to both the tile immediately before the target (along the attack path) and the defending piece.**

Interception:

- Defender announces a Guard to intercept.
- The Guard takes the damage instead of the original target.
- The attacker moves **1 tile** toward the target (stops on the tile immediately before the target).

Interception is optional. The defender may decline even if a Guard is eligible and can select which guard should take the damage if multiple Guards are eligible.

Only Move-Attacks can be intercepted. Skills always hit directly.

Skill Phase

You have **2 actions** per turn (at the start (see Progression)).

Spend 1 action to activate one equipped skill on one of your Champions or King:

- Announce the skill and the target.
- Pay the skill's Money cost.
- Apply the skill's effect.

The same Champion can activate multiple skills (also the same one) in one turn if you have actions remaining.

Skill System

Path: Skills travel in a **straight line** (horizontal, vertical, or diagonal) from the caster, like a chess Queen.

Blocking: The Path is blocked by **all pieces** — ally and opponent alike. The skill cannot reach past the first piece in its path.

Range: The distance in tiles along the Path from caster to target. Range is measured as:

- Range 0 = self (caster's own tile)
- Range 1 = adjacent tile along the Path
- Range 2 = 2 tiles away along the Path (etc.)

Default Range = 2. Unless a skill explicitly names “self” or “adjacent” in its effect text. A skill with a Range modifier (e.g. “Range –1”) is still a Range 2 skill with a modifier applied — it is not treated as adjacent or self.

Self vs. adjacent: “Self” skills (Range 0) target only the caster — they cannot target adjacent pieces, even with a Range buff. “Adjacent” skills (Range 1) target only neighbouring pieces — they cannot target the caster, even with a Range buff. Range buffs (e.g. Focus) shift the targeting window outward; they do not collapse it inward.

Injured Range penalty: Injured pieces have Range –1. Skills that explicitly name “self” or “adjacent” in their text are unaffected — they always work regardless of Injured status.

Skills that move pieces do not deal damage. Movement-via-skill (Dash, Swap, Retreat) does not count as a Move-Attack and deals no damage on arrival - you are instead stopped from moving the piece further in that direction.

A Champion may use its skills multiple times in the same turn if actions are available — including the same skill twice.

All skills cost 1 action unless noted otherwise.

Multi-Champion Combo Bonus

Each enemy piece has a **combo counter** (starts at 0, resets at the end of your turn). When a **Strike skill** hits it, deal **+counter damage**; if the hitter is a **new Champion** (one that didn't already increment this counter this turn), the counter then **+1**. Move-Attacks don't count. Buffs, heals, and movement don't count. Stacks with Charge.

Money

Starting Money: 6 per player.

Money income is collected at the **start of each player's own turn**:

Round	Income per player turn
1	0 (starting Money only)
2-4	+2
5-9	+3
10-14	+4
15+	+5 (+1 every 5 rounds)

No Money cap.

Progression

Round	Actions per Skill Phase
1-10	2
11-20	3
21-30	4
31+	5 (+1 every 10 rounds)

Health & Armor

All pieces have 2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed.

State	HP	Effect
Normal	2	No penalty
Injured	1	Speed capped at 1. Range -1 (affects Range 2+ only).
Removed	0	Piece leaves the board permanently.

Damage:

- 1 damage to Normal → Injured.
- 1 damage to Injured → Removed.
- 2 damage to Normal → Removed instantly (Injured state is skipped).

Armor: Max 3 points per piece. Each absorbs 1 damage, then destroyed. Resolves before HP damage. **Does not prevent Injured status.**

Skill Reference

	Cat.	Name	Cost	Effect
	Strike	Lance	2	Target within Range-1 takes 1 damage
	Strike	Hook	3	Target takes 1 damage, pulled 1 tile toward caster along the Path
	Strike	Break	2	Remove 1 Armor from target. <i>(Note: does not deal "HP-Damage" unless boosted by Charge)</i>
	Strike	Steal	3	Target takes 1 damage. Steal 1 Money from opponent.
	Strike	Tempest	4	Target takes 1 damage. All pieces adjacent to the target are pushed 1 tile away from the target. The attacker/caster is not affected.
	Shield	Shield	2	Self: gain +1 Armor
	Shield	Heal	3	Remove Injured from one adjacent ally
	Shield	Plate	3	Adjacent ally gains +1 Armor
	Move	Dash	3	Self: move up to 2 tiles along the Path
	Move	Blast	2	Push target enemy 1 tile directly away from caster
	Move	Shove	3	Push target enemy 1 tile in any direction (caster chooses). Range+1.
	Move	Swap	4	Swap position with an allied piece. Requires unobstructed Path.
	Move	Retreat	4	Self: move along the Path to land adjacent to one of your Guards. Range+1.
	Mystic	Focus	1	The next skill used by any of your pieces this turn gains +1 Range. <i>(Note: can boost self and adjacent skills — Range 0 → 1, Range 1 → 2.)</i> Move skills: the caster chooses, when activating the Move skill, whether the +1 applies to its activation range (how far the skill can target) or its effect range (how far it moves/pushes). Not both.
	Mystic	Charge	3	One Strike skill used by any of your pieces this turn deals +1 damage.

Quick Reference

Concept	Rule
Movement	Free pathing, ≤ speed in tiles, cannot pass through pieces. Each piece once per Move Phase.
Guard speed	Normal: 2 tiles. Injured: 1 tile.
Champion / King speed	1 tile (Normal or Injured).
Move-Attack	Move onto enemy tile (1 action). Deals 1 damage . Attacker stops before target if target survives.
Path	Straight line (Queen-style). Blocked by all pieces — ally and enemy.
Range	Default Range 2. Skills with “self” = Range 0. Skills with “adjacent” = Range 1. Range modifiers (e.g. Range–1) apply from default.
Injured Range penalty	Injured pieces: Range –1. Does not affect “self” or “adjacent” skills.
Bodyguard	Move-Attacks on Champion/King only. Guard must be adjacent to both tile-before-target AND defender. Guard takes the hit. Defender chooses which eligible Guard intercepts.
Armor	Max 3 per piece. Each point absorbs 1 damage before HP, then is destroyed. Does not prevent Injured status.
Health	2 HP: Normal → Injured → Removed. 1 damage = one step. 2 damage = skip Injured, Removed instantly.
Money income	Collected at start of YOUR turn (not Round 1). Starts 6, then +2/+3/+4/+5 scaling.
Skill Phase actions	Start at 2/turn. Grow with Progression (Rounds 1–10: 2, 11–20: 3, 21–30: 4, 31+: 5).
Focus	+1 Range to next skill this turn. Can boost self (→ adjacent) and adjacent (→ Range 2) skills. On Move skills, caster chooses: activation range OR effect range.
Charge	+1 damage to one Strike skill this turn. Stacks with Combo Bonus.
Combo Bonus	Each enemy has a combo counter (resets end of your turn). Strike skill hits enemy → deal +counter damage ; if hitter is a new Champion, counter +1. Move-Attacks excluded.